

Byunghwan ‘Ben’ Son

 4400 University Dr., George Mason University, 6B4, Fairfax, VA 22030
 bson3@gmu.edu;  kalkas@gmail.com;  703-993-9185;
 <https://textvulture.github.io/>;
 [@textvulture.bsky.social](https://textvulture.bsky.social); [Google Scholar](#)

Current Academic Positions

- George Mason University (Fairfax, VA)
 - Associate Professor (with tenure), [Global Affairs Program](#) 2020–current
 - * Assistant Professor 2014–2020
 - Director, [Asia–Pacific and Northeast Asian Studies](#) 2014–current
 - Director, [Korean Studies Center](#) 2025–current
 - * Associate Director 2020–2025
 - University Affiliate Faculty, [Schar School of Policy and Government](#) 2021–2022

Previous Academic Positions

- [The College of Wooster](#) (Wooster, OH)
 - Gillespie Visiting Professor (VAP), [Political Science](#) 2013–2014
- [University of Missouri-Columbia](#) (Columbia, MO)
 - Graduate Instructor, [Political Science](#) 2011–2013
- [Korean Air Force Academy](#)
 - Instructor, [Department of Military Strategy](#) 2003–2007

Education

- University of Missouri-Columbia (Columbia, MO)
 - PhD, Political Science 2007–2013
 - * Dissertation: Democratization and Exchange Rates
 - * Dissertation Committee: Jonathan Kriekhaus (Chair); Cooper Drury; Stephen Quackenbush; Vitor Trindade
- [Yonsei University](#) (Seoul, South Korea)
 - MA & BA, [Political Science](#) 1997–2003

Research & Teaching Areas

Politics of Global Finance; Comparative Political Economy; Politics in Asia; Causal Inference; Democratization; Democratic Backsliding; Democratic Support; Inequality & Contentious Politics; Political Communication; Computational Text Analysis; Quantitative Methods

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles Published

- 2025. “K-pop Fan Perceptions and Negotiation of Alternative Forms of Masculinities.” *Journal of Men’s Studies*. Forthcoming. (with Dae Young Kim). [\[Journal Link\]](#) [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2024. “Consequences of Democratic Backsliding in Popular Culture: Evidence from Blacklist in South Korea.” *Democratization*. 31(8): 1798-1822. [\[Journal Link\]](#)[\[PDF\]](#)
- 2024. “Foreign Policy Consequences of Democratic Backsliding: The Case of the Comfort Women Agreement 2015” *The Pacific Review*. 37(6): 1152-1176. [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2024. “The Political Economy of Life Satisfaction: Democracy, National Wealth, and Personal Income” *International Journal of Public Opinion Research*. 36(1): 1-14. (with Nisha Bellinger and Jonathan Kriekhaus). [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2024. “Foreign Pop Culture and Backlash: the case of non-fan K-pop Subreddits during the pandemic” *Journal of Cultural Economics*. 48(1): 117–143. [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2022. “The Health Cost of Autocratization” *Journal of Development Studies*. 58(5): 873-890. (with Nisha Bellinger). [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
 - Winner of the **Dudley Seers Memorial Prize**
- 2021. “Security Threats and Investment: North Korean Threats and the South Korean Stock Market” *Pacific Focus*. (with Chungshik Moon). 36(3): 544-569. [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2021. “Presidential Approval Ratings and Foreign Exchange Market: The Case of the Korean Won during the Park Government” *Asian Survey*. 61(5): 767–796. [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2020. “Doi Moi and Vietnamese Threat Perception of Chinese Economic Growth,” *Japanese Journal of Political Science* 21: 179-193. [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2020. “Interpersonal Trust and Confidence in Labor Unions: the case of South Korea,” *Journal of East Asian Studies* 20: 267-290. [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2020. “Democracy and Reserves,” *Foreign Policy Analysis* 16(3): 417–437. [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2019. “Political Parties and Foreign Direct Investment Inflows Among Developing Countries” *Political Studies* 67: 712–731. (with Nisha Bellinger) [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2018. “The Mysterious Overvaluation of KRW in the 1990s,” *The Pacific Review* 31: 573– 597. [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2018. “Democratization and Currency Crises in Latin America,” *Journal of International Relations and Development* 21: 442–463. (with Jonathan Kriekhaus) [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2016. “Are the Poor the Weak Link? Democratic Support and Income Levels in Post-Crisis South Korea,” *Journal of East Asian Studies* 16: 219-237. [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2016. “Policy Choices in Tough Times: The case of democratization and currency defense,” *International Political Science Review* 37: 453-469. [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)
- 2015. “Economic Coercion and Currency Crises in Target Economies,” *Journal of Peace Research* 52: 448-462. (with Dursun Peksen) [\[Journal Link\]](#); [\[PDF\]](#)

- 2014. “Inequality and Democratic Support,” *Journal of Politics* 76: 139-151. (with Jonathan Kriekhaus, Nisha Bellinger, and Jason Wells) [[Journal Link](#)]; [[PDF](#)]

Papers Under-review

- “Income Levels and Institutional Confidence” (*Revise & Resubmit*)
- “Petition the Emotion” (with Myunghee Lee) (*Revise & Resubmit*)
- “A tale of two crises” (with Nisha Bellinger)
- “Democratic Backsliding and Financial Data Transparency”
- “Fan political engagement” (with Dae Young Kim)
- “Democratic Backsliding and Central Bank Independence”

Projects in Progress

- “Insurrection Attempt and Stock Market”
- “Discourse of Economic Security” (with Jihye Lim & So-hyun Park)
- “Conservative Parties and Democratic Backsliding”

Book Review

- 2024. *Supercorporate: Distinction and Participation in Post-hierarchy South Korea* by Michael Prentice. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2022. xiii, 248 pp. ISBN: 9781503631878.
– *Journal of Asian Studies* 83(1): 187–188. [[Journal Link](#)]

Chapters

- “Income inequality: A distant but significant threat to South Korea’s democracy” 2022
– in R. Hass & P. Kim Eds., *Democracy in Asia*. Brookings Institution. Washington DC.

Other Writings & Media Appearances

- Comments on South Korea’s local elections 2026
– Quoted in “[South Korea ruling party fails to flip Seoul](#)” AFP (France 24).
- Comments on the political economy of South Korea’s rocket launch 2025
– Quoted in “[South Korea’s Rocket Launch Marks Shift to Commercial Space Race](#)” Bloomberg.
- “South Korean Democracy Prevailed. But it wasn’t guaranteed” 2024
– Op-ed in [MSNBC](#)
- Comments on the US Presidential Election 2024
– interview in “[This is Washington](#)”, Voice of America Radio, Korea
- Comments on South Korea’s Space Program 2024
– Quoted in “[South Korea Is Gearing Up to Become Space Powerhouse](#)” Bloomberg
- Comments on the politics of the doctors’ strike in South Korea 2024
– Quoted in “[How row over medical school thwarted Korean president](#),” Times Higher Education
- Comments on the Legislative Election in South Korea. 2024
– Quoted in “[‘Lame Duck’ S. Korean President Reels From Election Debacle](#)” AFP (The Barron’s)
– Quoted in “[South Korea General Election: Four Key Figures](#)” AFP (The Barron’s)
- “[Democratic Backsliding as a Threat to Regional Cooperation in East Asia](#)” 2023
– Korea On Point. Invited contribution.
- “The Retreat from Kabul is NOT a sign of declining American Hegemony” 2021
– Op-ed in [Pressian](#) (Korean).

- Comments on “[Korea-US Summit 2021](#)” NewsUp, CBS Radio (Korean) 2021
— also featured in [Nocut News](#); [Hankookilbo](#) (Korean).
- “The Causes of Biden’s Victory and its Implications” 2020
— Op-ed in [Pressian](#) (Korean)
- “Is Authoritarianism Bad for the Economy?” (with N. Bellinger) [The Conversation](#) 2019
— Translated in Portuguese at [Gazeta do Povo](#).
- “Party Systems Matter for FDI Inflows” [PSA Blog](#) 2019

Invited Talks, Lectures, Panels & Roundtables (excluding GLOA in-house talks)

- “Conversation with Former Vice Foreign Minister of South Korea” 2025
— Round Table. Brookings Institution. In-person
- “K-pop Fans in the US” 2025
— [Public Diplomacy Lecture Series](#). [Jeonbuk National University](#), South Korea
- “Inequality and Democracy in South Korea”
— Democracy in Asia Panel Discussion. Brookings Institution. In-person. 2022 (Nov.)
— Democracy in Asia Workshop. Brookings Institution. Virtual. 2022 (Mar.)
- “Big Data Panel Discussion” 2022
— Urban Research Hub Method Series, [CSSR](#), GMU
- “South Korea’s role in regional economic architecture and supply chain resilience” 2021
— Workshop (roundtable). Brookings Institution. Virtual.
- “[The End of War Declaration in the Korean Peninsula and Vision 2030](#)” 2021
— Round Table. [Institute of National Security and Strategy](#). Virtual.
- “Democratic Backsliding and Human Security” 2021
— Public Lecture. [Hankuk University of Foreign Studies](#) Virtual.
- “Affective Polarization and Right-Wing Populism” 2021
— Public Lecture. ‘EverySecondSaturday7PM’ (local activists’ society) Virtual.
- “Autocratization and Public Health Outcomes” 2020
— Invited talk. [Institute of Korean Studies](#). University of Missouri, Columbia. MO. Virtual.
- “Presidential Impeachment in South Korea and Financial Market” 2017
— Invited talk. Korean Studies Center. George Mason University, Fairfax. VA.
- “Obama Administration’s Pivot to Asia” 2016
— Invited Talk (student-organized). George Mason University, Fairfax. VA.
- “KRW in the 1990s” 2016
— Public Lecture. Korean Studies Center. George Mason University, Fairfax. VA.
- “Is Democratization to Blame for the Economic Difficulties of S. Korea?” 2014
— Invited Talk. George Mason University, Fairfax. VA.
- “Territorial Disputes in East Asia” 2013
— Guest Lecture. [Lincoln University](#). Jefferson City, MO.
- “Democratization and Exchange Rate Policies” 2013
— Invited Talk. Korean Fellow Society, Harvard University, Boston MA.

Grants, Awards, & Fellowships

- [4VA Grant](#). \$15,000 2022
 - with Dae Young Kim (GMU) Younga Jung (GMU), and Yoon Hwa Choi (UVA)
 - [Commonwealth of Virginia](#)
- [Faculty Research and Professional Development Award](#). \$14,288 2020
 - with Dae Young Kim and Younga Jung, [College of Humanities & Social Sciences](#), GMU
- Global Democracy Fellow. \$2,000 2017
 - [Korean Democracy Foundation](#)
- [Faculty Research and Professional Development Award](#). \$3,636 2016
 - [College of Humanities & Social Sciences](#), GMU
- Online Course Development Grant. \$4,000 2016 to 2017
 - [GMU Online Course Development Institute](#)
- [J.G. Heinberg Fellowship](#). 2009–2010
 - One semester’s tuition and stipend. University of Missouri
- [Brain Korea 21 Scholarship](#). 2002
 - Stipend of about \$3,600. Yonsei University, South Korea.

Conference Presentations

The latest 10 projects.

- “Authoritarian Successor Parties and Democratic Backsliding”
 - Midwest Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL. 2026
 - American Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Boston, MA. 2026
- “Democratic Backsliding and Financial Markets: the Case of South Korea in 2024-5”
 - International Studies Association Annual Meeting, Columbus, OH. 2026
 - Midwest Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL. 2026
- “Income Levels and Institutional Confidence”
 - International Studies Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL. 2025
 - Midwest Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Virtual. 2021
 - International Studies Association Annual Meeting, New Orleans, LA. 2015
- “Fandom and Political Participation: the case of K-pop fans”
 - International Studies Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL. 2025
- “Democratic Backsliding and Central Bank Independence”
 - American Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Philadelphia, PA. 2024
- “Democratic Backsliding and Financial Statistics Transparency”
 - American Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Philadelphia, PA. 2024
 - Midwest Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL. 2024
- “Fiscal Policy Regimes in Asia Across Two Crises” (w/ Nisha Bellinger)
 - American Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Philadelphia, PA. 2024
 - Midwest Political Science Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL. 2024
- “Behavioral impacts of K-pop” (w/ Dae Young Kim)
 - Eastern Sociological Society Annual Meeting, Washington DC. 2024
- “K-pop and Male Masculinity” (w/ Dae Young Kim)
 - Eastern Sociological Society Annual Meeting, Philadelphia, PA. 2023
- “Fan Perspectives on Racism in K-pop” (w/ Dae Young Kim)
 - Eastern Sociological Society Annual Meeting, Washington DC. 2024
 - Eastern Sociological Society Annual Meeting, Philadelphia, PA. 2023

Courses Taught

- George Mason University
 - Economic Globalization and Development (MA) every semester
 - Interdisciplinary Research Method (MA)
 - Capstone Seminar (MA)
 - Case Studies in Globalization: Globalization in Asia (MA)
 - Global Affairs Capstone (BA)
 - Globalization in Asia (BA)
 - Global Politics and Revolutions (BA)
 - Introduction to Global Affairs (BA)
 - * Online section development [GMU OCDI](#) 2017
 - * recognized as “[Outstanding](#)” teaching by GMU multiple years
 - Korea in Global Perspective (BA & MA)
- The College of Wooster
 - Independent Studies supervisor for nine senior students
 - International Political Economy
 - Introduction to International Relations
 - East Asian Politics
- University of Missouri-Columbia
 - East Asian Politics
 - Introduction to International Relations
- Korean Air Force Academy
 - Readings on the First World War
 - Introduction to Defense Studies
 - Arms Control
 - The Sociology of Civil-Military Relations

Services

- To Global Affairs Program (GLOA), GMU
 - Search Committee
 - * chair, Administrative Assistant Search 2026
 - * chair, Assistant Professor, GLOA-SIS joint hire 2021
 - * chair, Associate Professor, GLOA-Communication joint hire 2020
 - * member, GLOA Director 2020
 - * member, Term Assistant Professor (Songdo Campus) 2019
 - * chair, Graduate Coordinator 2019
 - * chair, Assistant Director 2018
 - * chair, Graduate Coordinator 2018
 - * member, Assistant Director 2016
 - GLOA Multi-Year Term Faculty Renewal Committee 2021
 - GLOA Bylaw Committee 2020–current

- Curriculum/Academic Advising GLOA BA/MA students 2014–2020
- Graduate Advisory Committee, Global Affairs 2015–current
- Executive Committee, Global Affairs 2015–2020
- Organizer, GLOA Faculty Brownbag 2016–2017
- Director Renewal Committee 2016, 2023
- Textbook Renewal Committee (GLOA 101) 2016
- GLOA promotion video 2022
- To the College of Humanities and Social Sciences (CHSS), GMU
 - Curriculum Committee 2025 to 2026
 - Intellectual Life of the College Committee 2023 to 2026
 - Senior Leadership Committee 2020 to 2023
 - Director, Asia-Pacific & Northeast Asian Studies Minor 2014–current
 - Term Faculty Promotion Committee. MCL. 2021
 - Judge, Diversity Webpage Re-design Competition. Dept. of Psychology 2019
 - Judge, Annual CHSS Undergraduate Research Symposium 2015, 2016, 2017, 2019
 - Adviser for visiting scholars, [Korean Studies Center](#) 2016–current
 - Search Committee
 - * member, RELI/MCL joint, Assistant Professor 2024
 - External Dissertation Committee
 - * Yukiko Furuya, Sociology 2016–2020
- To George Mason University
 - Search Committee
 - * Chair, Assistant Case Manager, Academic Standard Committee 2026
 - Member, Academic Standard Committee 2024-current
 - * formerly GMU Honor’s Committee
 - Faculty discussant for Mason Graduate Interdisciplinary Conference 2023
 - Focus Group for Tenure-track Faculty Experience 2016
 - Panelist, New Faculty Orientation 2015
 - Grant Proposal Reviewer
 - * Provost Multidisciplinary Research Initiatives. 2015, 2016
 - Photo models for GMU promotion materials 2019, 2025
- To the profession
 - Editorial Board 2019-current
 - * [East and West Studies](#) (interdisciplinary peer-reviewed journal)
 - Reviewer for book proposals
 - * Routledge 2024
 - Reviewer for grant proposals
 - * APSA Doctoral Dissertation Research Improvement Grant Review Panel 2025
 - Discussant / Chair
 - * APSA 2014, 2017, 2019, 2024, 2026
 - * MPSA 2014, 2019, 2021, 2022, 2025, 2026

- * ISA 2026
- * [GWIKS](#) Workshop 2021
- * DC-Area Comparativist Workshop 2017, 2019
- * DC-Area International Relations Workshop 2024
- Conference/Section/Panel Organized
 - * Association of Korean Political Studies, Related Group Section 2023-2024
 - American Political Science Association Annual Meeting. Philadelphia. PA.
 - * [The Korean Wave in North America](#) 2021
 - Virtual. With Dae Young Kim and Young A Jung (GMU)
- Professional Leadership
 - * Vice President, [Association of Korean Political Studies](#) 2024-2026
- Reviewer for peer-reviewed journals
 - * *American Journal of Political Science; Asian Journal of Peace Building; Arts and International Affairs; Asian Survey; British Journal of Political Science; Comparative Political Studies; Comparative Politics; Constellation; Defence & Peace Economics; Economics & Politics; Emerging Markets Finance and Trade; European Journal of Korean Studies; Foreign Policy Analysis; Global Perspectives; International Interactions; International Political Science Review; International Studies Quarterly; International Studies Review; Japanese Journal of Political Science; Journal of Asian Political Science; Journal of Asian Studies; Journal of Conflict Resolution; Journal of East Asian Studies; Korea Observer; Pacific Focus; Pacific Affairs; Political Research Quarterly; Politics & Policy; Studies in Comparative International Development*

References

- Dr. Jonathan Kriekhaus. University of Missouri-Columbia
- Dr. Cooper Drury. University of Missouri-Columbia
- Dr. Matthew Krain. The College of Wooster

Last Update: August 25, 2026